

Jens E Rasmussen

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Adam Hyllested, Anders Richardt Jørgensen,
Jenny Helena Larsson et Thomas Olander

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New Thoughts on an Old Curse (Tab. Ig. VIb 60/VIIa 49)

Brent Vine
University of California, Los Angeles

0. Introductory

Among the most striking and well-known passages of the Iguvine Tables is the curse against the enemies of the Umbrian state (VIb 60, repeated with minor spelling variations at VIIa 49). The text consists of five alliterating pairs of 3 sg. imperative ("future imperative") forms; in the VIb 60 version:

tursitu . tremitu [.] hondu . holtu . ninctu . nepitu . sonitu . sauitu . preplotatu . preuilatu[1]

In context, the syntax at VIb 60 is aberrant, as compared with VIIa 49: in the latter passage, the subject of the 3 sg. imperatives is the goddess Tursa Iovia (invoked at VIIa 47), who is asked to perform the various actions expressed by these verbs ("She shall terrify [them], ..." etc.), whereas at VIb 60, the subject of the 3 sg. imperatives is actually a trio of divinities (Çerfus Martius, Prestota Çerfia, Tursa Çerfia, invoked at VIb 57-8), which might have been expected to yield plural imperatives. The problem has been usefully discussed by Prosdocimi (1978: 758, see earlier Poultney 1959: 279), and will not concern us here further, except to note that at bottom, such a feature underscores the highly formulaic nature of this text, which in turn is consistent with a composition of great antiquity, despite its appearance in the later portions of the Tables.

Beyond this problem, the curse text itself carries two main points of interest: first, as the longest alliterative sequence in the Iguvine Tables (and thus in extant Umbrian), it is of considerable interest as part of the growing body of ancient Italic alliterative compositions (cf. n. 4 below); and secondly, it is notable for the semantic and etymological opacity of the central section, consisting of the three pairs *hondu holtu, ninctu nepitu,* and *sonitu sauitu.* The aim of the pre-

[1] VIIa 49 is identical except for the variants *sunitu, preplohatatu,* and *preuiçlatu.* Despite Olzscha (1958: 304), there is little reason to consider the variation in *preuilatu/preuiçlatu* as phonologically significant, a point that cannot be pursued here.

sent contribution, therefore, is correspondingly twofold: I present, first, a series of observations, in a somewhat "Jakobsonian" vein (cf. many of the studies in Jakobson 1981), about the poetic structure of the text, in an attempt to go beyond the relatively limited commentary of this sort hitherto provided; and secondly I provide etymological discussion of some of the more recalcitrant material in the central section, with particular reference to *holtu* and *sauitu*. As a by-product, I will have occasion to consider how these two aspects of the text – i.e., poetics and etymology – may in fact have some relationship one to the other, as well as broader implications for the interpretation of the text.

The paper is offered as a modest tribute to Jens Elmegård Rasmussen, whose erudition, passion, and intellectual courage have long served – and will continue to serve – as an inspiration to many.

1. Poetics

Previous attention to the poetics of this text has been limited. Beyond the alliteration itself, the repeated preverb of *preplotatu preuilatu* has been compared with similar patterns in Latin (most famously *con- … com- … con- … com-* in the Senatus Consultum de Bacchanalibus; thus Watkins 1995: 223, Costa 2000: 114). The near-isosyllabism of the alliterative pairs has often been remarked (e.g. Prosdocimi, loc. cit.), including the observation that the inexact match of *ninctu nepitu* could be rendered perfect by assuming a relatively recent syncope in the first item, as the *-nct-* spelling itself seems to indicate. More interesting (and thus far underexplored) is an intriguing parallel with the Oscan curse text Ve 3 (most explicitly Prosdocimi 1992: 401f., recapitulated by Costa 2000: 114). After the initial naming of the person to be cursed (**stenim . kalauiiúm . tri** 'Stenium Calavium, Tre(bi filium)'; the accusative is governed by a verb like Lat *mando* 'I entrust, hand over', to be supplied after **tif[eí]** 'tib[i]' in the final line), the text enumerates various of the victim's items to be affected, using exactly five alliterative pairs, just as in the Umbrian curse (**aginss . urinss . úlleis. / fakinss . fangvam / biass . biítam . aftiím . <a> / namúm . aitatum / amirikum**, conventionally rendered 'actiones, orationes illius, facinora, linguam, uires, uitam, spiritum, animam, aetatem, quaestum').

Nor does this exhaust the parallels between these texts. Consider, for example, the rhythmic structure in terms of syllables: in the Umbrian curse, it is striking that the first four pairs of two or three syllables (i.e. *tursitu tremitu hondu holtu ninctu nepitu sonitu sauitu* = 3 + 3, 2 + 2, 2/3 + 3, 3 + 3) are "capped", as it were, by the concluding longer pair (*preplotatu preuilatu* = 4 + 4), as if to provide a rhythmically "clausular" effect. It does not seem to have been noted that the Oscan text exhibits much the same pattern. Here, a fairly rigorous 2 + 2 syllabic sequence for the first four pairs of nouns (**aginss . urinss, fakinss . fangvam, biass . biítam**, etc.[2]) is capped by the longer final sequence (**aitatum / amirikum**, 3 + 4, or perhaps rather 3 + 3, depending on one's interpretation of the anaptyxis, cf. n. 2).[3] An additional parallel will be noted below (§ 1 ad fin.), and attention may also be drawn, at this point, to a striking *difference* between the two texts: the Oscan text (like alliterative compositions elsewhere in Italic, including Umbrian itself) allows vowel-alliteration, in contrast to the strict consonant-alliteration of the Umbrian curse.[4]

Let us consider several further details concerning the segmental phonetics of the alliterating sounds themselves. Superficially, the word-initial sequences (*t- t-, h- h-, n- n-, s- s-, pr- pr-*) seem to contrast the *Cr*-cluster of the fifth pair with the generally *C*-initial pattern of the first four pairs, perhaps as another "clausular" effect. The first pair, however, actually shows *tur- tr-*, which, together with the closing *pr- pr-*, could be interpreted as displaying a limited bit of phonetic "ring composition".

This correlation between the first and fifth pairs could actually be tightened – at least if viewed historically – by adopting a particular morphological interpretation of *tursitu*. The Italic **torseio/e-* underlying this form is traditionally interpreted as an *o*-grade causative, i.e. (PIE) **tors-éio/e-*. Such a form, however, would show Schwebeablaut (the root is **tres-*: Ved. *trásati* etc.); thus Nussbaum (1999: 412n87) may be correct in assuming, rather, an ultimate zero-grade **trs-*, cf. Latin zero-grade iteratives like *sorbēre* 'gulp down' < **srb^h-éio/e-* (beside the *o*-grade iterative *ῥοφέω* 'id.' < **srob^h-éio/e-*; root **sreb^h-*).[5] If this is correct, the initial pair **tr(C-) *tr(V-)* would match the final **pr- *pr-* rather more precisely – but necessarily only at a "pre-Italic" stage. To pursue this line of argument still further (if more speculatively), it is interesting to note that the primordial sequences one might suppose, of the type 1 **trseietōd *tremeietōd* (or perhaps even a still earlier **tros- *trom-*, with the "correct" causative root shapes) vs. 5 **praiplautāietōd *praiuinkelāietōd* (i.e., 4 + 4 vs. 5 + 6), would recover, respectively, two of the verse lengths normally reconstructed for the PIE "short line" (as reflected, for example, in Vedic octosyllablic pādas) and "long line" (as in triṣṭubh hendecasyllabic pādas). Nor is it difficult to find, in other IE traditions,

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2 The genitive specifier **úlleis** attached to the first pair could be considered "extrametrical" (or otherwise extraneous), and the surface 2 + 3 sequence in **aftiím . <a> / namúm** might conceivably reflect an underlying 2 + 2 pattern, given the late anaptyxis in **<a>namúm**.

3 The "strophic" diagrams of both texts provided by Watkins (1995: 220f., 223) seem to reflect a similar conception of this clausular patterning, though without specific reference to the rhythmic organization.

4 For a detailed survey of alliterative patterns in Italic, see Janson 1993.

5 A similar analysis could be applied to *Tursa* < **trs-éh$_2$* (for the zero-grade type, cf. perhaps *fuga*), as opposed to the *o*-grade **tors-* usually assumed (see Untermann 2000: 776).

similar textual patterning involving multiple imperatives,[6] so that the text type itself may have an older pedigree than is generally assumed. Such details may strike some as fanciful, and perhaps rightly so; but the general point is that some features of this text (including several to which little or no attention has been paid before) may hint at an extremely archaic background to the text's composition, or (to put it differently) the possibility that the text, if viewed through a diachronic lens, may preserve traces of very old compositional techniques otherwise known to be important for Indo-European poetics, such as ring composition.[7]

Some final comments on the consonantal material (before turning to vocalic patterning) concern the nature of the segmental inventory reflected in the alliterating sounds, i.e.:

- (voiceless) *stops* /p/ and /t/, both plus *liquid* /r/
- *aspirate* /h/ (from earlier velar fricative; more on this point below, in § 2)
- *sibilant* /s/
- *nasal* /n/

Apart from the absence of vowel-alliteration (already noted), which seems significant (however it is to be interpreted), the absence of /k/ is somewhat surprising: cf. Janson's survey of the relative frequency of consonant types in South Picene and other Italic alliterative compositions (1993: 156), which shows that while /p/ predominates, /k/ and /t/ are equally frequent. We will have occasion to return to this point at the end of § 2 below. The other general feature that seems striking is the *broad phonetic representation* across virtually all major categories of the Umbrian consonant system (stops, fricatives [including sibilant], liquid, nasal). It does not seem too farfetched to propose a broadly "iconic" interpretation of this feature, i.e. as a reinforcement of the message being conveyed. The precise semantic interpretation of this iconism must remain elusive, but several possibilities (not necessarily mutually exclusive) come to mind. If one thinks in terms of the addressees of the message, which are spelled out with elaborate specificity in the text immediately preceding the curse itself (namely, the four enemy nations, chief citizens in office and not, men under arms and not), the broad phonetic representation could help reinforce the *inclusiveness* of the targets of destruction. Similarly, if one focuses instead on the destructive actions specified in the curse itself, this phonetic feature could reinforce the *comprehensiveness* or *varied nature* of the afflictions being requested.

[6] E.g. RV 10.184.1: *víṣṇur yóniṃ kalpayatu / tváṣṭā rūpáṇi piṃśatu / á siñcatu prajāpatir / dhātā́ gárbhaṃ dadhātu te.*

[7] I note in passing that recent work by A. Mercado (2003) suggests that the prosodic approach to the Latin Saturnian meter sketched by Parsons (1999), itself based on the theory of the quantitative trochee as applied to Latin prosody by Mester (1994), may also be applicable to the rhythm of Umbrian ritual language. If this turns out to be correct, some of the details of the above analysis will need to be viewed in a somewhat different light.

Similar considerations emerge from a closer look at certain vocalic patterns. If we operate at a "phonemic" level (thus bearing in mind the low-level *o* > *u* rule that has applied in the root syllable of *tursitu,* cf. Meiser 1986: 116), the root vowels of these ten verbs show the following pairings:

1 o / e
2 o / o
3 i / e
4 o / a
5 o / i

As with some of the consonantal material, it is difficult to know which features are to be judged "significant" in some way. Nevertheless, certain descriptive patterns seem striking, first of all (once again) the *variety* of these patterns (every one is different), together with the prominence of /o/, which appears as the root vowel of the first vocable in all but the central pair, and which is totally absent in the central pair. One could again consider an "iconic" interpretation of such patterning, in terms of a reinforcement of the *insistence* or *inevitability* (vel sim.) of what is being expressed. Moreover, the special status of the central pair points once again to a "ring composition" effect in terms of vowel quality, along the following lines:

back – front
  back – back
    front – front
  back – back
back – front

Further, the prominence of /o/ in this text recalls the prominence of /a/ in Ve 3 (**aginns, fakinss, fangvam, aftiím, <a>namúm, aitatum, amirikum**); and still more strikingly, the central pair with front-vowel root vocalism exactly matches the same feature in Ve 3 (**biass, biítam**).[8] Finally, just as it was possible to "tighten" the ring composition patterning by viewing the consonantal material diachronically, a similar result for the vocalic patterning arises (as will be seen later) from part of the etymological discussion, to which we now turn.

[8] I owe this last observation to Benjamin W. Fortson IV (personal communication).

2. Etymology

As to be expected for Umbrian, the ten lexical items in this text run a gamut of etymological certainty from the more or less transparent to the painfully obscure.[9] Broadly speaking, one can set up the following hierarchy, I believe relatively uncontroversial:

- "Tier I" (transparent/widely agreed upon, even if some details remain unclear): *tursitu, tremitu, preplo(ho)tatu, preui(ç)latu*
- "Tier II" (less clear, but with attractive possibilities, including some that are favored by many [or by prominent] authorities): *hondu, holtu, ninctu, sonitu/sunitu*
- "Tier III" (largely obscure): *nepitu, sauitu*

My initial aim (§ 2.1) will be to argue, contra received opinion, for the "demotion" of *holtu* to "Tier III", and then to offer what may be a new etymological suggestion for the form. Secondly (§ 2.2), I will propose a reinterpretation of an existing (though neglected) etymological account of *sauitu,* which turns out to have interesting consequences for Umbrian (and Italic) historical phonology, as well as for the poetic analysis of the text in question.

2.1. *holtu*

The standard etymology of *holtu* takes the form to reflect a *$*h_3élh_1$-tōd,* with the root of ὄλλυμι 'destroy' etc., and therefore with a non-etymological *h-* (after its alliterating partner *hondu,* and/or some other similar material). I cannot fathom how such an interpretation can have been so blithely condoned by so many for so long.[10] The instability of /h/ in Italic, to be sure, is well known; but a composition of this sort is not Catullus 84. No comparable instance in any other Italic alliterative text is known to me. Nor is the comparison with *hebetafe* (VIb 53) of any real import for the question: this form (apparently the designation of a ceremonial location) is sometimes adduced as another example of non-etymological *h-* (cf. *ebetrafe* VIa 12), in support of the standard analysis of *holtu* (thus e.g. Poultney 1959: 279). But the *h-* of *hebetafe* has several possible explanations, none of them strictly comparable with the secondary *h-*

[9] We now have recourse to the enormously useful compendium by Untermann (2000; helpful critique in Dunkel 2000), to which reference is hereby made globally for detailed bibliographical information, including material cited here by author's name only, given limitations of space.

[10] Similarly Meiser (1986: 84) on the older interpretation of *ninctu* as 'overwhelm with snow' ("In der Tat ist es einigermaßen verwunderlich, daß Huschkes lautlich, syntaktisch und inhaltlich gleichermaßen problematische Deutung solchen Anklang gefunden hat"), and his similar rejection (op. cit. 115) of the traditional interpretation 'deafen with noise' for *ṣonitu* (more on which below).

claimed for *holtu* (i.e., none involving a contamination).[11] Also different in character is the consistent *h-* of **habina** (Ia 27 etc.), assuming the traditional connection with Lat. *agnus* 'lamb' etc. is correct: the generalized lexical contamination (presumably involving a word similar to Lat. *haedus* 'kid' or the like) is of a different sort from the episodic contamination assumed for *holtu.*[12] The salient point is that this analysis of *holtu* is simply untenable in terms of the poetic background of this text: the systematic comparison with Ve 3 makes clear that the alliterative scheme involves five consecutive alliterating pairs, with a restriction to consonant-alliteration – how, then, can one accept the hypothesis that the second pair was originally composed as non-alliterating (i.e., *hondu *oltu*), but was secondarily adjusted by attaching a non-etymological *h-* to the second item?

Equally unsatisfying is another traditional comparison, with the theonym **hule** (IV 17, a deity correlated with **turse** at IV 19). There is, one must admit, a superficially appealing aspect to this comparison, insofar as *hondu* has been compared (though perhaps speciously) with the apparent theonym *honde*/**hunte** and *tursitu* may well be connected with the theonym *tursa*/**turse** (cf. above). But the comparison leads nowhere, and is really a case of *obscurum per obscurius*: the hapax **hule** (dat. sg.) is itself quite opaque; nor, in any case, can *holtu* reflect a regular denominative formation based on **hule** (f., nom. *__hula__?), as Poultney correctly notes (loc. cit.). The other etymological suggestions for *holtu* recorded by Untermann (2000: 328)[13] have little to recommend them, beyond the fact that they all take seriously the initial *h-* – a *sine qua non,* as I see it, for a satisfactory etymology.

Although it is subject to the usual qualifications associated with root etymologies, a connection with *$*ĝʰel-$* 'cut' (IEW 434) may be worth considering, a suggestion that I have not seen elsewhere. There are no primary verb forms traceable to this root (hence its absence from LIV), but this does not mean that such a verbal root cannot be reconstructed: forms like Li. *žúolis* 'piece of wood, branch' (*$*ĝʰōl-i̯o-$*),[14] OWelsh *gylym* (MW *geleu/gelyf*) 'knife' = OE *gielm* 'sheaf' (*$*ĝʰel-mo-$*), and Go. *gilþa* 'sickle' (*$*ĝʰel-tā$*) are certainly consistent with an old verbal root; and for the semantics, note enlarged forms like ON *gelda* 'castrate'.[15] The absence of actual reflexes of a primary verb, however, makes it

[11] Esp.: error for <*ehe*->, or else connected with the final *-e* of the preceding word, e.g. as a hiatus-breaker (see Untermann 2000: 318 for details).

[12] Nor is the traditional etymology of **habina** by any means unassailable, although this must be left aside here.

[13] Cf. *$*ĝʰelh₃-$* 'green, yellow' (Prosdocimi); cf. χόλος 'bile, anger' (Pauli); *__hondle-tōd__ to *__honto-__ 'below' (Ribezzo).

[14] Perhaps (if originally an *i*-stem) pointing to an old root noun? On Baltic *i*-inflection of original root nouns, see Larsson 2001: 53.

[15] Here also, perhaps, "Phryg." Γάλλοι 'castrated followers of Cybele'.

hazardous to specify a morphological source for *holtu,* about which one can only speculate. In terms of form, *holtu* could be explained, for example, on the basis of a zero grade **ĝʰl̥-tōd* (as if from a generalized athematic active weak stem), or via a full grade (thematic or athematic) **ĝʰol-(e-)tōd,* i.e. an original *o*-grade present (a well-established class that includes a number of other "verbs of violent action", however the *o*-grade type is to be accounted for in PIE terms).

2.2. *sauitu*

Strictly speaking, little is actually known about *sauitu.* While it is true that Untermann's estimations of the current state of our knowledge tend to be highly conservative (all to the good, in certain respects, for such a work), his judgment "B[e]d[eutung] unbekannt … Et[ymologie] ohne B[e]d[eutung]-Bestimmung ungesichert" for *sauitu* (2000: 658) is perfectly accurate. At the same time, however, the form is very widely conjectured to have some relationship with Lat. *saucius* 'wounded' (thus von Planta, Buck, Devoto, Pisani, Olzscha, Poultney, Ancillotti-Cerri, among others), e.g. via a pre-Latin **sau̯-ikio-*. This comparison – highly attractive semantically, in context – is problematic in the extreme, since the background of *saucius* (Liv. Andr.+) is entirely unclear (cf. WH s.v.: "unerkl[ärt]"). What, one may ask, is the mysterious "**sau̯-*" on which this comparison appears to be based? Nor does a formation in **-ikio-* inspire much confidence from the Latin perspective: Lat. *-icius* exclusively makes adjectives based on titles (*aedīlicius,* etc.) and then secondarily festival names (*lūdī aedīlicii* → *Sāturnālicius,* etc.), probably from a limited starting point in a form like *patricius* (Leumann 1977: 301).[16] Yet despite these problems, the comparison with Lat. *saucius* offers, both formally and semantically, by far the best hope available for interpreting U. *sauitu,* and deserves to be salvaged if it possibly can.[17]

Now given the difficulty of finding suitable etyma involving *s-* < **s-* (there is no "**sau̯-*", and other such forms with **s-* have little appeal [cf. n. 17]), we should consider more carefully possibilities of the sort *s-* < **Cs-*, especially since the most attractive etymology of *sonitu* (Pisani, followed by Meiser and others) operates with an Italic **ksoneio/e-* < PIE **kp̑on-éio/e-* (or, in "pre-thorn" format, **tken-*, i.e. the root of κτείνω 'strike, kill' etc.). Indeed, conjectures of just this sort have already been proposed for both *saucius* and *sauitu*:

[16] The Lat. *-icius* forms sometimes adduced in this connection (*nouīcius, suppositīcius,* etc., thus e.g. Poultney 1959: 281) are of no value, given the discrepancy in vowel length.

[17] There is no space here to comment in detail on various unattractive alternatives proposed for *sauitu*: cf. Lat. *saeuus/saeuiō* (Bücheler); cf. Skt. *savyá-* 'left' (Nazari); cf. **seu̯-* 'press out' (Ribezzo 1936).

- *saucius*: cf. Ved. *kṣá-* 'burn', ξηρός 'dry' (Hirt)
  cf. ψαίω 'rub' or ψαύω 'touch' (Wood)[18]
- *sauitu*: cf. Ved. *kṣṇu-* 'whet' (RV *kṣṇaumi*), ξύω 'scrape' (Ribezzo 1931)

Of these, Ribezzo's comparison with a verb meaning 'scrape' or the like is immediately appealing, despite major difficulties, first and foremost with the root vocalism. There is again no "**ksau̯-*", just as there was no "**sau̯-*"; but there *is* good evidence, as Ribezzo saw, for an old verbal root **kseu̯-* (see LIV s.v.): in addition to the direct testimony of ξύω, note also Ved. *kṣurá-* 'razor' = ξυρόν 'id.', and (despite LIV, which sets up a separate root **ksneu̯-*) probably also original *n*-infix forms (in addition to RV *kṣṇaumi* also Lat. *nouācula* 'razor').[19] The problem may now be restated in the following terms: the central difficulty, addressing *sauitu* first, is to account in a natural way for the transition from an old **ksou̯-éio/e-* (presumably iterative, 'scrape/wound again and again') to the Italic **(k)sau̯eio/e-* that can underlie *sauitu.* There is, I suggest, an elegant solution, via "Thurneysen-Havet's Law", the process that accounts for Lat. *caueō* 'beware of' (: κοέω 'perceive') < **kou̯H-éio/e-*, and a number of other similar forms.[20] Of particular interest is the fact that this process has hitherto been established only for Latin, in the absence of quotable instances from Italic dialects. Nevertheless, there is every reason to suspect that this development could well have operated outside Latin, as emerges from consideration of its relative chronology: it must precede not only **Vgʷ/gʷʰV* > **Vu̯V* (which must belong to a very early stratum of Latin; hence *foueō* 'warm', not ***faueō,* etc.), but also precedes **eu̯* > **ou̯* (thus *nouus* 'new', not ***nauus,* etc.), which is normally assumed to be a Proto-Italic innovation. It is no surprise, then, that Schrijver concludes his detailed study of the chronology of Thurneysen-Havet's Law by observing (1991: 453) that the process "can in principle be very old", and Meiser (loc. cit. [n. 20]) has arrived at the same conclusion, explicitly asserting that in theory, the rule is "auch für das Sabellische gültig". If the present analysis of U. *sauitu* is accepted, it would thus provide valuable corroboration for the operation of Thurneysen-Havet's Law outside Latin.

What, then, can be said about Lat. *saucius*? To begin with, a similar account via Thurneysen-Havet's Law is certainly not excluded: somewhat parallel would be *raucus* 'hoarse' reflecting **rau̯iko-* (Leumann 1977: 340f., cf. *rauus* 'id.' and *rauis* 'hoarseness' possibly < **h₃rou̯H-o-/*h₃rou̯H-i-* [: Ved. *ruváti* 'roars' etc.], cf. Schrijver 1991: 258). But the morphological details are difficult to specify, as

[18] See WH (s.v.) for further details.

[19] On the entire complex, see in these terms García Ramón 2000: 121 (including consideration of enlarged **ks-en-* and **ks-es-* beside our **ks-eu̯-*, originally to **kes-* 'ordnen': OCS *česati* 'comb' etc.).

[20] For full discussion and earlier references, see Schrijver 1991: 436ff. (more recently Meiser 1998: 85).

with some other Lat. *-io-* adjectives "ohne faßbare Grundwörter" (*pius, ēbrius,* etc., Leumann 1977: 291). One may suggest the following tentative scenario, the details of which have little bearing, in any case, on the analysis of U. *sauitu* proposed above. An original **ksou̯o-* 'scraping' (either a τόμος or τομός form, depending on how one conceives of the semantics) could have served as the basis for a nominal *k*-derivative **ksou̯-V́k-* 'a scrape, wound', which fits well with the existence of a whole series of such Latin stems denoting body part terms and "Körperschäden".[21] This **ksou̯-V́k-*[22] would then have been ousted by *uulnus* (probably belonging to a higher register, as with other Lat. **-n-es-* forms), but not before serving as the basis for a possessive adjectival derivative **ksou̯-V́k-i̯o-* (or perhaps by that time already **sau̯k-io-*) 'having a wound, wounded'.

Let us sketch, finally, some of the implications of this interpretation of *sauitu* for the poetic and semantic analysis of the Umbrian curse.

On the level of phonetics, and at some rather early "pre-Umbrian" stage, the proposed pre-form **ksou̯e̯ietōd* would exhibit the same root vowel as that of the preceding *sonitu,* in which case the ring composition pattern involving root vocalism (§ 1 ad fin.) becomes more marked: /o/ would appear in *both* items of *both* the second and fourth pairs, straddling the central pair, with its highly marked front vowels. Moreover, a **ksou̯e̯ietōd* would harmonize with the **ksone̯ietōd* (< PIE **kṛ̥pon-ḗi̯o/e-*) now regarded as a strong possibility for *sonitu,* thereby providing – though necessarily at a very early stage – an alliterating *k*-sequence, the absence of which is otherwise noteworthy, as observed above.

Insofar as the above etymological analysis provides further support for a meaning like 'wound' or 'maim' for *sauitu,* and given recent advances in the analysis of some other items (cf. above on *sonitu*), it may now be possible to view the text as more coherent semantically than has been thought, although there is no space here to explore the ramifications of such an approach. One could, for example, view the sequence as displaying a "logical" or "chronological" progression (rather than a more or less random list of desired afflictions), consisting roughly of three steps in a *process*:

TERRIFY (x2)	*tursitu tremitu*
KILL, MAIM (x3 ?)	*hondu holtu, ninctu nepitu, sonitu sauitu*
TRAMPLE + BIND	*preplotatu preuilatu*

It has already been suggested (see Untermann 2000: 577) that the 'binding' may refer, metaphorically, to the treatment of animals (perhaps involving a

[21] Lat. *pollex* 'thumb, big toe', *pōdex* 'anus', *pantex* 'paunch, bowels', *rāmex* 'blood vessel, hernia', *varix* 'varicose vein', *famex* 'bruise, contusion' (Leumann 1977: 375).

[22] Ultimately > Lat. *"saux, saucis",* if it had survived long enough.

terminus technicus referring to the forelegs of cattle). It might further be conjectured, with all due reserve, that this series of actions (TERRIFY → KILL/MAIM → TRAMPLE + BIND) could even correspond to some ritualized behavior, such as might be enacted with enemies defeated in war. As for the internal structure of the central KILL/MAIM portion: the etymological suggestions discussed above regarding *holtu* and *sauitu,* both of which would be based on roots meaning 'cut' or 'scrape' (i.e., both falling into the MAIM category) may hold some interest both for the interpretation of *nepitu,* which remains unclear,[23] as well as for the preceding items in each pair, where KILL or something like it is a strong possibility for *sonitu* (as already noted), and is certainly among the contenders for both *hondu* and *ninctu* (see Untermann s.vv. for details).

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[23] I am not persuaded by any of the traditional accounts, the most popular of which involves a meaning 'annihilate' based on a pronominal **ne-pi-* 'no one, nothing' (see Untermann 2000: 491 for details).

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